

additional contextual information if necessary. There is a section for “How do I...” which lets you explain particular tasks, such as “locking the door”, “using the washing machine” or “clean out the garbage”. You can add multiple ways to answer the question to get the same response. You can create as many custom responses as you want. Once you are done, tap on **Next: Update Skill**. You can also provide contact information for doctors, taxi services and so on in a **Contact Info** segment. You can then set a custom welcome message, a list of random phrases to greet the guest every time they interact with the Echo, and an Exit or Farewell message when they stop interacting with the Echo. Then, pick a name for the skill, which is the trigger phrase you need to inform your guest about. Click on **Create Skill**. This process may take up to two minutes. This time period is not there in the previous example of configuring a custom response. Most other Blueprints based Skills however, take some time. Once created, you can add or edit a skill, and delete them if no longer required. Note that Skills created with Blueprints are personal, and available only on your Echo device. You can however, choose to share your skills with friends, or publish them as well.

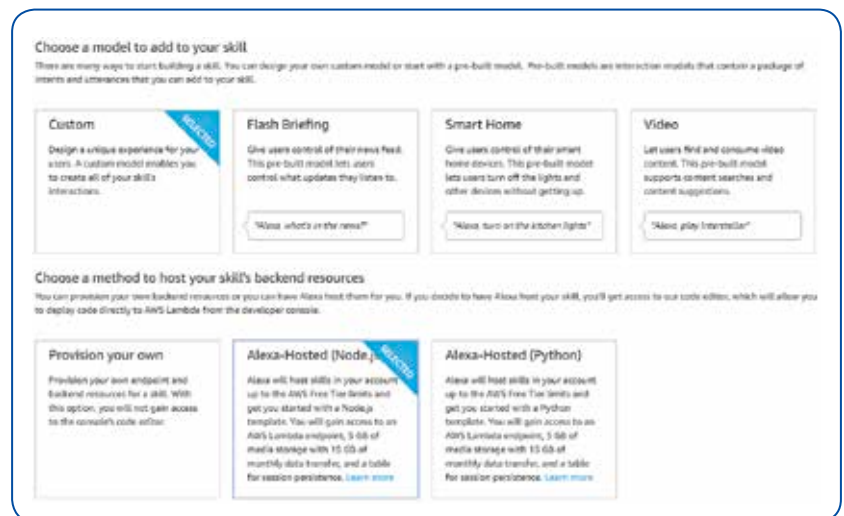
THE DEVELOPER CONSOLE

Now, we will be publishing our own skill. First, you will need to get an Amazon developer account. To do so, go to developer.amazon.com. You will have to provide a name, which will be the attribution if you publish your skill. The registration process is instant. Go to the **Alexa Developer Console**, and then click on **Create Skill**. Create a name for the skill, we are going to go with **Indian States** in this example. Now, you will have to select a model, which is a more complicated version of Blueprints. One of the simplest models available is the option of creating your own Flash Briefing, but that requires you to configure your own backend. Do note that, you can create and host skills locally, which is great for testing skills. We will be starting with something simpler. Select **Custom** as the model, and **Alexa-Hosted (Node.js)** as the backend.

This gives you a free Amazon AWS Lambda endpoint, where you can store 5 GB of data, with a 15 GB data cap per month. Now you have to choose a template. From left to right, the templates increase in complexity, starting with a simple **Hello World**. Select the third one, which is **Quiz Game Skill**, and click on **Choose**. Now, you will see an Interaction Model, with an **Invocation**, as well as **Intent** and **Slot Type** sub menus. The **Invocation** is the phrase that people will use to start this skill. We will go with **Indian States quiz** here.

Install Notepad++, this is an easier way of editing the code than Amazon's Developer console. Now, go to the spreadsheet program of your choice, and make an array that when copy pasted, shows up this line as a single example `{StateName: 'Andhra Pradesh',`

`tion getSmallImage(item) {}`, and we used spark.adobe.com to create these graphics. Note that this skill is going to be publicly deployed, so it is good to make custom graphics. They show up in Echo devices with a touchscreen. Now, find and replace **admitted to the Union** in with **established as a state** in. It's as simple as that, we are done. Copy all the text, go back to Alexa Developer Console, and replace all the code in **index.js**. If you have made any errors in the code, the line will show a red cross. Click on **Save**, then on **Deploy**. This will take some time. Now go back to **Build** and build the model again. Try creating your own unique quiz, or other skill. Once you are done, test the skill using the **Test** tab. This gives an interface identical to the Echo, and you can create skills even if you do not have an



The Amazon Developer Console

Abbreviation: 'AP', Capital: 'Amaravati', StatehoodYear:2017, StatehoodOrder:26}. Fill out all the data for the states in this format. Once you have put in all the information, copy and paste the array to replace the code between the square brackets of `const data = []`. Then, find and replace all **United States** with **India**. Now, look for **fifty states** and replace it with **twenty eight**.

Amazon provides all the resources needed to train yourself to start building skills on the developer subsite. There is a course to familiarise with the Alexa Skills Kit as well as tutorials on the design aspect of skill creation such as Voice UI and monetisation. You also need to add images for func-

Echo. Once you have verified that it works as expected, you can go ahead and publish it. Click on **Distribution**, and change the descriptions to remove all traces of **US**. You also have to make and upload small and large icons. Fill out the **Privacy** and **Compliance** information, then choose availability settings. You can choose to release the skill all over the world, or in particular regions only. Now, the skill will get validated through an automated error checking system. Once that is done, click on **Run** to send the skill for certification. Now go to **Certify** and **Publish**, and you should be done. Do not try this with this exact same quiz, as it has been done many times before.

